The Threat of Displacement

Eviction Filing Patterns in Chicago: 2010, 2015, 2019

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Introduction

There is a reason we call it the housing **crisis.** Living without permanent shelter has disastrous effects on one's mental and physical health, access to employment opportunities, and community relations. Everyone needs affordable shelter; however, America lacks an adequate supply of affordable housing. The Institute for Housing Studies estimates that, as of 2021, Chicago alone requires an additional 119,435 units to meet affordable housing demand (The Institute for Housing Studies at DePaul University, 2023). 47% of Illinois renters are rent-burdened (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago, 2026).

Tenants are reminded of the housing crisis at the beginning of every month and at the end of every lease. Current policy discussions include bans on single-family zoning, missing middle development, and lifting mandatory parking minimums. These are potential ways to increase housing supply, which, in theory, would lead to lower rents. However, rental housing is underscored by the implicit threat of violence: eviction, the lawful removal of tenants from a rental property by the landlord. If a tenant does not pay rent every month, armed law enforcement agents will forcibly remove them from their home. In our current housing system, homelessness is a government creation.

In Cook County, Illinois, the eviction process begins when the landlord delivers a Tenancy Termination notice stating that the tenant has violated their lease and outlining the steps to resolve the violation (Cook County Sheriff's Office). If the tenant does not comply with the notice, the landlord files an eviction lawsuit with the Circuit Court. If the landlord chooses to proceed with the lawsuit, a Sheriff's Officer serves the tenant with a court summons. If the court rules in the landlord's favor, it will issue an official eviction order setting a move-out deadline for the tenant. If the tenant has not moved out by the deadline, Sheriff's Officers will forcibly remove them (Cook County Sheriff's Office).

This paper examines the spatial pattern of evictions in Chicago and the household characteristics associated with a high risk of eviction. I measure ***eviction filings***: the stage of the process in which the local government officially gets involved. This metric is important because most eviction filings do not result in tenant displacement.

Literature Review

Economic Factors of Eviction

Eviction researchers believe that failure to pay rent is the most common reason landlords file eviction lawsuits (Garboden & Rosen, 2019). In the rental industry, success is measured by vacancy rate and rent nonpayment rate. Evicting a tenant solves the nonpayment problem but also creates a vacancy, and depending on the housing market, this vacancy could mean a few months of missed rental revenue (Garboden & Rosen, 2019). Additionally, the eviction process requires expenses that the landlord is responsible for. In some jurisdictions, the initial eviction filing requires a fee; in Cook County, the fee ranges from $287 to $388 (Clerk of the Circuit Court of Cook County). If the landlord decides to pursue the case in court, they must pay for a lawyer. There are costs associated with winning: the landlord must pay for cleaning and potential repairs. If the tenant moves while still owing rent, most landlords report that the chances of being repaid are close to zero (Garboden & Rosen, 2019).

These costs shape a landlord's approach to eviction. For example, smaller landlords, who own just a few units, are more likely to figure out a repayment plan with their tenants. Because eviction expenses are a greater share of their revenue, nonpayment must exceed eviction and vacancy costs for the landlord to seek tenant removal (Garboden & Rosen, 2019). In contrast, larger corporate landlords, who may own hundreds of units, file evictions at a higher rate (Garboden & Rosen, 2019; Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020; Robinson & Steil, 2021). The eviction costs are a smaller part of their overall revenue. In these buildings, eviction policy is set by the corporate owners, but the execution is delegated to the property manager. This manager may have little control over changing policy: corporate priorities are to hit profit targets and reduce tenant risk (Garboden & Rosen, 2019; Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020). As a result, these filings may not remove the tenant, but they serve as a tool to ensure rent payments and generate more income for the property owner.

Late fees on missed rent payments serve as an additional revenue source for landlords (Garboden & Rosen, 2019; Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020). These fees vary, sometimes ranging from $60 to 5% of rent (Garboden & Rosen, 2019). In corporate buildings, formulas that include late fees help determine property managers’ annual bonuses. Eviction filings for missed rent help landlords enforce this extra debt, and late fees often offset filing costs (Garboden & Rosen, 2019).

How the Threat of Eviction Harms Tenants

Eviction filings fundamentally shift power in favor of landlords over tenants. Once a landlord files for eviction due to missed rent, they can pursue removal at any time. This enables landlords to evict tenants for reasons that would otherwise be inadmissible (Garboden & Rosen, 2019). Tenants who have complained about conditions or tried withholding rent to force repairs become vulnerable if they miss a single day of rent. The threat also shapes behavior: landlords report fewer complaints from tenants who have an eviction filed against them (Garboden & Rosen, 2019).

Eviction threats can severely limit tenants' future housing options. Property owners conduct background checks, in which both filed and completed eviction records appear. As a result, landlords may hesitate to lease to tenants they perceive as risky, pushing these tenants into worse housing conditions (Robinson & Steil, 2021). For tenants using Section 8 vouchers, the stakes are even higher: a completed eviction disqualifies them from the program (Garboden & Rosen, 2019). Filing for eviction perpetuates the cycle of housing insecurity, disproportionately impacting marginalized communities in America.

Household Characteristics of Eviction

Black tenants are disproportionately affected by eviction, a pattern highlighted across the reviewed literature (Graetz et al., 2023; Lawyers' Committee for Better Housing, 2019; Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020; Robinson & Steil, 2021). In their demographic analysis of the U.S. evicted population, Graetz et al. found that black renters were the only racial group overrepresented in eviction filings and judgments. Black Americans made up only 18.6% of all renters yet were 51.1% of those threatened with eviction and 43.4% of people who were fully evicted (Graetz et al., 2023).

Eviction filing rates are consistently higher in Black-majority areas across multiple cities. Regional analyses in Boston and Atlanta have shown that Black-majority areas are associated with elevated eviction filings (Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020; Robinson & Steil, 2021). The same pattern is evident in Chicago: in

2017, Black-majority community areas had an eviction filing rate 3.1 percentage points above the citywide average and 4.8 points above white-majority areas. Chicago data further show that Latine-majority areas have filing rates 1.3 points higher than those in white-majority areas (Lawyer's Committee for Better Housing, 2019).

The findings of one study add an additional perspective to this phenomenon. In their analysis of formal and informal evictions in Milwaukee, Desmond & Gershenson (2017) found that Black and Latine tenants were not statistically more likely to be evicted, after controlling for other economic variables. The authors believe this may be due to Milwaukee's current racial and economic segregation. This segregation creates segmentation in the local housing market: if a landlord owns a building in a poor, Black majority neighborhood, and they evict their Black tenants, they are unlikely to replace them with wealthier, white ones (Desmond & Gershenson, 2017). The bias of racist landlords may be restricted by economic forces.

Families with children are another group with a high risk of eviction. At the national level, adult renters living with at least one child had an annual eviction rate of 10.4%, while adults without children had a rate of 5.0% (Graetz et al., 2023). This was even worse for Black mothers, with annual eviction filing rates of 28.4%, whereas the rate for Black women living without children was 16.3% (Graetz et al., 2023). Between 2007 and 2016, children were present in 52% of the household files. Graetz et al. estimate that out of the ~7.6 million individuals evicted in each of these years, nearly 2.9 million were children.

Desmond & Gershenson (2017) also found that a renter with one child had a 9.5% chance of receiving an eviction filing within the year, and a renter with two children had an 11.7% chance. The authors believe landlords may be financially motivated to avoid children. Children can contribute to property damage and noise complaints. They can also attract unwanted attention from the state: welfare or child services agents may inspect some tenant households, and these agents can report unsafe living conditions that the landlord may be responsible for (Desmond & Gershenson, 2017). Also, it may be easier for landlords to replace tenants with children with adult-only households. If the local tenant base in a segregated city is economically and racially the same, children are one factor that can fluctuate.

Eviction is more common among renters who struggle to pay rent, as research on the economic status of people facing eviction demonstrates. Immergluck et al.

found that in a sample of multifamily rental buildings in Atlanta, every 10-percentage-point increase in rent burden among renters was associated with a 0.6-percentage-point increase in one-time eviction filings. A similar study based in Boston also found a small but significant association between eviction filings and rent burden within a census tract (Robinson & Steil, 2021). The Milwaukee study found that tenants who had lost their jobs within the past year were at higher risk of eviction (Desmond & Gershenson, 2017). While rent burden and job loss are statistically significant predictors of eviction, the literature found no direct connection between household income, rent prices and eviction rates (Desmond & Gershenson, 2017; Graetz et al., 2023; Robinson & Steil, 2021; Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020). However, the significance of rent burden suggests an eventual breaking point: renters can only pay so much of their income toward rent before they start neglecting other necessities. Rent increases may lead to other forms of tenant displacement.

Neighborhood and Property Characteristics of High-Eviction Areas

Displacement is widely recognized as a consequence of gentrification: traditionally, this process entails the replacement of working-class residents by wealthier, whiter newcomers. Yet whether such displacement stems primarily from eviction remains unclear. Hepburn, Louis & Desmond (2024) analyzed ~6 million eviction filings to determine whether they were more prevalent in gentrifying census tracts. Their findings challenge expectations: three-fifths of evictions occurred in low-income tracts that did not exhibit the demographic and income changes linked to gentrification. In contrast, gentrified areas saw greater declines in eviction rates over time and were less prone to annual spikes in evictions. At the metropolitan scale, higher rates of gentrification did not correspond to greater evictions, which were most common in underinvested neighborhoods (Hepburn, Louis, & Desmond, 2024).

However, when studying eviction at the individual property level, research finds that rental housing typically in high-income areas is associated with unique eviction risk. Robinson & Steil (2020) investigated eviction dynamics in market-rate, multifamily housing in Boston. They found that eviction filings were more likely in properties with higher assessed values than in those with lower values within the same census tract. Tenants in newly constructed or renovated buildings were also slightly more likely to receive eviction filings than tenants in the average building in the same census tract. However, they also found that older buildings were associated with higher eviction rates, a finding shared in other studies (Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020; Humphries, Nelson, Nguyen, Dijk, & Waldinger, 2024).

Immergluck et al. (2020) investigate the factors associated with multifamily buildings that have high serial and non-serial eviction filing rates. In their analysis, the number of units in a building is significantly and positively associated with the serial filing rate, suggesting that larger, corporately owned buildings file evictions at a higher rate than smaller buildings. This research also found that buildings sold to new owners within the same year exhibited eviction-filing behavior indicative of a strong intention to remove tenants.

This literature shows a complicated relationship between eviction and gentrification. When studying eviction rates at the census tract level, evictions are centered in poorer neighborhoods (Hepburn, Louis, & Desmond, 2024; Desmond & Gershenson, 2017). Hepburn et al. suggest one potential explanation for this finding is housing growth. They found that between 2000 and 2016, gentrifying neighborhoods increased their rental housing stock by 25%, and low-income neighborhoods saw a 16% increase in renter-occupied units (Hepburn, Louis, & Desmond, 2024). The authors hypothesize that this new housing allows new residents to move in without directly replacing current tenants through eviction. Displacement instead occurs when poorer residents are priced out of their current units and cannot afford the new housing built in their neighborhood. However, the type of housing built in these areas matters. New construction is one indicator of gentrification, and increases in multistory, corporately owned homes could increase the eviction filing rates (Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020; Robinson & Steil, 2021).

Eviction Filing and the Ability to Pay Rent

The landlords interviewed in the qualitative literature treat missed rent as the de facto reason for filing eviction cases, and they have an economic incentive to do so. Filing helps landlords collect missed rent, late fees, and evict tenants for any other reason (Garboden & Rosen, 2019). Eviction is a decision the landlord makes, and missed rent makes it easier for them to proceed.

Due to the decentralized nature of eviction data, it is difficult for quantitative research to pinpoint the specific motivation behind eviction. In Cook County, online court records do not provide specific reasons for eviction filings (Lawyer's Committee for Better Housing, 2019). Eviction cases are formally categorized as Possession of Property Only, Distress for Rent, or Joint Action (possession of property and rent) (Clerk of the Circuit Court of Cook County). However, in an analysis of Chicago eviction cases from 2010 to 2017, the Law Center for Better Housing found that 82% of filed cases made claims for back rent (Lawyer's Committee for Better Housing, 2019). This adds weight to the claims that failure to pay rent is the most common reason a landlord files for eviction.

Research Questions

This paper builds on this existing research and explores it in the Chicago context. I explored two research questions, which investigate the spatial pattern of eviction filings in Chicago, and what property and household characteristics are associated with a higher eviction filing rate.

Research Question 1

Are there clusters of census tracts with high and low eviction filing rates in Chicago? If so, what are the differences between demographics, housing costs, and income between these clusters?

Research Question 2

What is the relationship between a census tract's eviction filing rate, median assessed property values, and the percentage of households with children?

Methodology

Data Overview

Eviction Data

The eviction rate data comes from the Lawyers' Committee for Better Housing's (LCBH) eviction data portal, which contains data on 350,000 eviction court records on cases filed during the calendar years of 2010-2019 with the Circuit Court of Cook County (Lawyers' Committee for Better Housing, 2020, p. 2). This paper examines residential eviction cases filed within the City of Chicago, totaling 225,710 filings for

2010-2019 (Lawyers' Committee for Better Housing, 2020, p. 3). The majority of this paper's research only examines data from 2010, 2015, and 2019. These years have 24,390, 23,356, and 18,220 residential filings, respectively. The main variable of interest in this paper is the Eviction Filing Rate, which the LCHB defines as the number of eviction filings per 100 rental units in a census tract.

Housing, Income, and Demographic Data

The data on housing, income, population, education, and racial demographics came from the American Community Survey (ACS) 5-year Estimates, accessed through the National Historical Geographic Information System (NHGIS) Data Finder. The 5-year Estimates used are from 2006-2010, 2011-2015, and 2015-2019. The variables of interest are: total population, total population that is Black, total population that is Latino, total households, total households with at least one child, total population twenty-five or older, total population twenty-five or older with a bachelor's, master's, professional, or doctoral degree, median household income, total population in the labor force, total population in the labor force that is unemployed, total housing units, total vacant housing units, total occupied housing units, total owner-occupied housing units, total renter-occupied housing units, median rent, and median rent-to-income ratio.

Median Assessed Property Value

The property value data comes from the Cook County Assessor's Office Open Data Portal, which provides the land, building, and total assessed values for all Cook County parcels since 1999. The data were filtered to create three datasets listing parcel values for townships adjacent to Chicago for the tax years 2010, 2015, and 2019. The assessed property value parcel data was joined with georeferenced parcel data to determine the census tract each parcel was located in. This paper will define assessed property value as the Board of Review Certified Total Value, which the County defines as a parcel's combined land and property values that have been assessed by the Cook County Board of Review (Cook County Government, n.d.).

Data Management

In Python, the eviction, ACS, and property value data were combined to create three unique datasets: one for each year (2010, 2015, and 2019). The 2010 data used eviction data from 2010, ACS data from 2006-2010, and property value data from 2010; the 2015 data used eviction data from 2015, ACS data from 2011-2015, and property value data from 2015; the 2019 data used eviction data from 2019, ACS data from 2015-2019, and property value data from 2019.

Each row in the data represents a Chicago census tract, and the separate data sources were joined using the ten-digit census ID as the common key. After combining the three data sources, any census tract with a total population of 0 was dropped. The final number of census tracts: 797 for the 2010 data, 798 for the 2015 data, and 798 for the 2019 data. The eviction data required little cleaning: it was already organized by census tract, so extracting the eviction filing rate was the only manipulation needed.

The ACS data required normalization, so new variables were created: the percent of the population that is Black, the percentage of the population that is Latine, the percentage of households with at least one child, the percentage of the population with a bachelor's degree or higher, the population of the labor force that is unemployed, the percentage of the housing that is vacant, the percentage of the housing that is owner occupied, and the percentage of the housing that is renter occupied. These variables were created by dividing the part by the whole; for example, the percentage of the population that is Black was calculated by dividing a census tract's total Black population by its total population. The variable "bachelor's degree or higher" includes individuals with a bachelor's, master's, professional, or doctoral degree. These percentage variables, along with median household income, median rent, and median rent-to-income ratio, are the variables used in my analysis.

The property value data was clipped to the Chicago boundaries to include only parcels within the city. Then, parcels with an assessed value of zero were removed from the data set (these parcels were 1.51% of the 2010 parcels, 1.4% of the 2015 parcels, and 2.51% of the 2019 parcels). The final parcel counts in the data are 838,074 in 2010, 836,008 in 2015, and 838,074 in 2019. These parcels were then grouped by census tract to determine the median assessed property value for each tract in Chicago, which will serve as the property-value variable in the analysis.

Research Question Methodology

For my first research question, I used ArcGIS Pro to run a Local Moran's I analysis to identify clusters and outliers among census tracts with high and low eviction filing rates. In this test, spatial relationships are defined as census tracts that share a boundary, a node, or an overlap. I ran this test three times: one for each of the 2010, 2015, and 2019 data sets. After running this test, I created a table that compared the eviction filing rates, housing, income and demographic characteristics between the high and low-rate clusters. I also created a table comparing the same variables across the high- and low-rate outlier tracts.

For the second research question, I used a Tweedie Regression model to investigate the relationships between a census tract's eviction filing rate, median assessed property values, and the percentage of households with children. Eviction filing rates are my dependent variable; median assessed property values and the percentage of households with at least one child are my independent variables; median household income, the percentage of housing that is vacant, the percentage of housing that is owner-occupied, and the median rent-to-income ratio are my control variables.

I used Tweedie Regression because the dependent variable had multiple valid zero values I wanted to include in my analysis. Originally, I was going to include all the variables included in my first research questions as control variables. However, after running a Variance Inflation Factor test on the regression model, I detected high multicollinearity among the other housing, rent, and demographic variables. Although household income did show multicollinearity, I believe it is relevant to the dependent variable and should be retained.

Additional data manipulation was required for this test. A census tract with an unusually high median assessed property value was dropped. In each year of the data, this tract's property values were ~$1,000,000 higher than the others. After removing this tract, the final tract counts for the data: 796 in 2010, 797 in 2015, and 797 in 2019.

Results

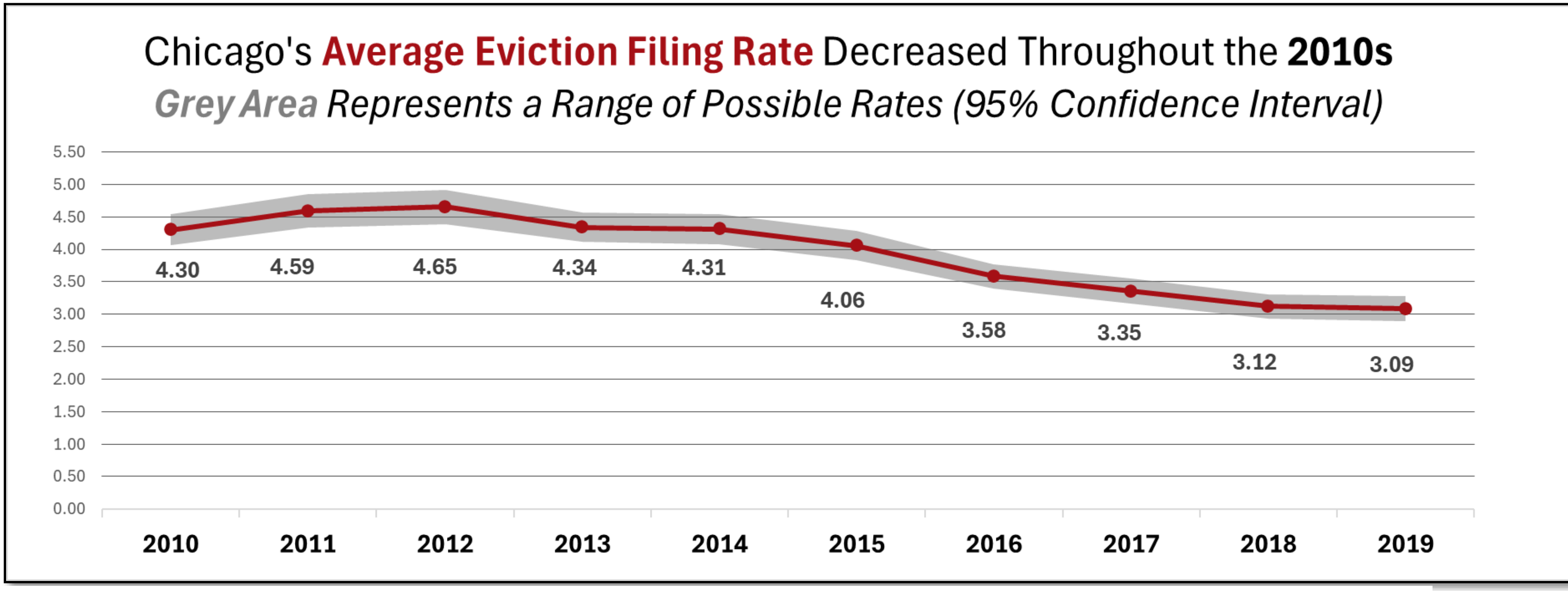


Figure 1

Measures of Central Tendency and Variance by Year

Year	*Total Filings*	*Average Rate*	*Median Rate*	*Standard Deviation*	*Standard Error*	*Lower 95 CI*	*Upper 95 CI*	*Margin of Error*
2010	24,390	4.30	3.55	3.46	0.12	4.06	4.54	0.24
2011	25,334	4.59	3.88	3.66	0.13	4.34	4.84	0.25
2012	26,389	4.65	3.94	3.81	0.13	4.39	4.91	0.26
2013	25,201	4.34	3.60	3.33	0.12	4.11	4.57	0.23
2014	24,507	4.31	3.57	3.40	0.12	4.07	4.54	0.24
2015	23,356	4.06	3.19	3.20	0.11	3.83	4.28	0.22
2016	20,439	3.58	2.86	2.77	0.10	3.39	3.77	0.19
2017	19,529	3.35	2.65	2.77	0.10	3.16	3.55	0.19
2018	18,345	3.12	2.18	2.71	0.10	2.94	3.31	0.19
2019	18,220	3.09	2.15	2.79	0.10	2.89	3.28	0.19

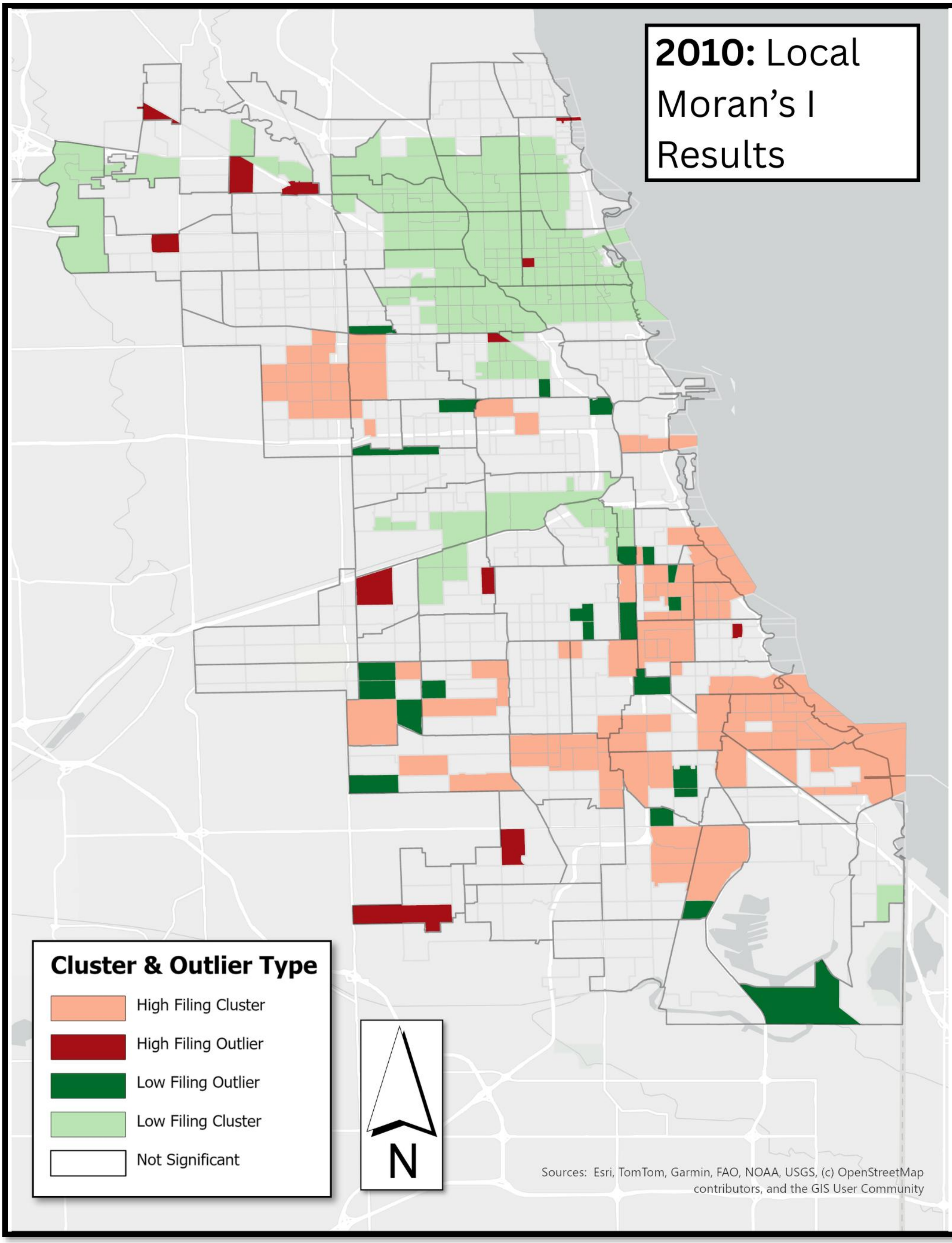
n = 804 Census Tracts

Table 1

Chicago-Wide Eviction Filing Rates

First, I explored the Chicago-wide eviction filing rate for each year from 2010 through 2019. This data came directly from the LCHB and did not undergo the same data management steps as the data in the other research questions: it contains 804 census tracts, including tracts with a total population of zero. However, there are only six to seven additional tracts in this analysis; that number is small enough that I do not believe it will drastically affect the results. The purpose of this graph is to provide a reference of the city-wide eviction filing rate before exploring areas of high and low rates.

Figure 1 shows the Chicago-wide eviction filing rate for each year from 2010 to 2019. The red markers are the average eviction rate, and the grey area represents a range of possible rates. Filing rates started at 4.3 in 2012, peaked at 4.65 in 2012, then decreased each year until reaching a low of 3.09 in 2019. Table 1 shows the measure of central tendency and variance of Chicago's filing rate. Each year has a large standard deviation, indicating that filing rates among census tracts are farther from the city-wide rate. The median filing rate is lower than the average rate in each year of the data set, suggesting high-rate tracts are skewing the average to the right.



2010: Local Moran's I Results
Cluster & Outlier Type
High Filing Cluster
High Filing Outlier
Low Filing Outlier
Low Filing Cluster
Not Significant
N
Sources: Esri, TomTom, Garmin, FAO, NOAA, USGS, (c) OpenStreetMap contributors, and the GIS User Community

Figure 2

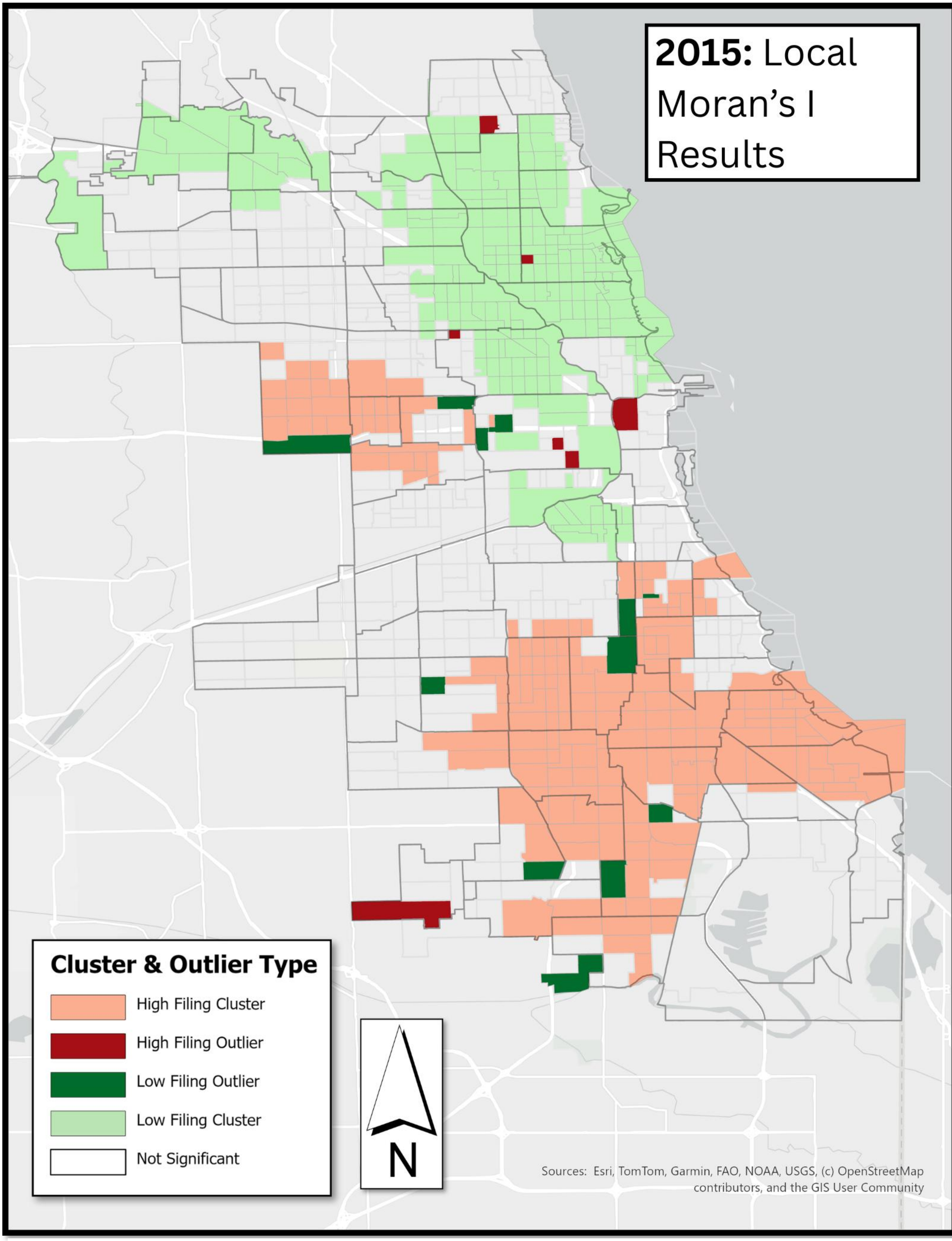
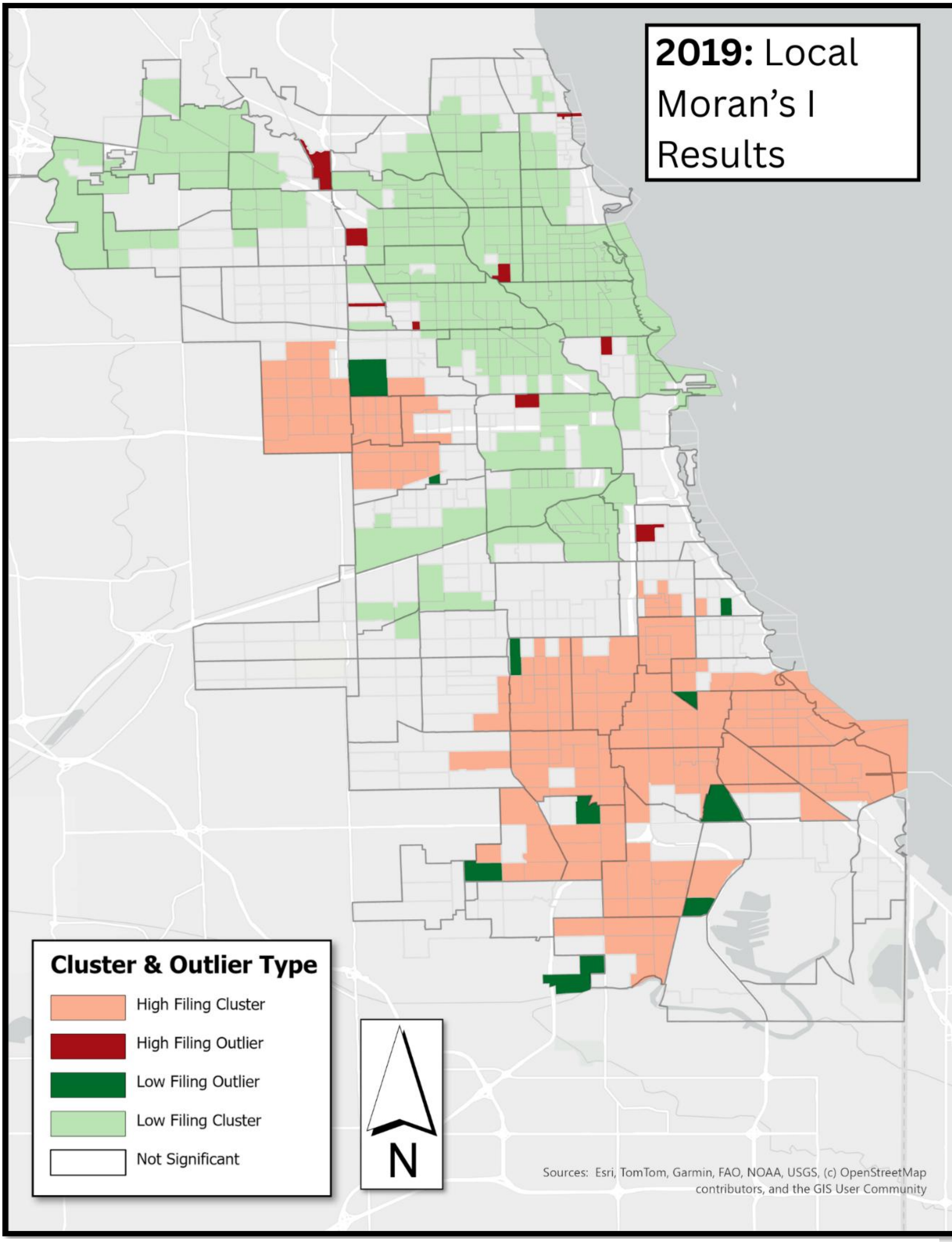

2015: Local Moran's I Results
Cluster & Outlier Type
High Filing Cluster
High Filing Outlier
Low Filing Outlier
Low Filing Cluster
Not Significant
N
Sources: Esri, TomTom, Garmin, FAO, NOAA, USGS, (c) OpenStreetMap contributors, and the GIS User Community

Figure 3



2019: Local Moran's I Results
Cluster & Outlier Type
High Filing Cluster
High Filing Outlier
Low Filing Outlier
Low Filing Cluster
Not Significant
N
Sources: Esri, TomTom, Garmin, FAO, NOAA, USGS, (c) OpenStreetMap contributors, and the GIS User Community

Figure 4

Spatial Pattern of Eviction Filing

Local Moran's I Results

The results of the Local Moran's I analysis show that eviction filing rates are not randomly distributed across Chicago in 2010, 2015, and 2019. Figures 2, 3, and 4 show clusters of census tracts that have statistically significantly high or low eviction filing rates. The light red areas are high-rate clusters, and the light green areas are low-rate clusters. The dark red areas are high-rate outlier tracts near low-rate clusters, and the dark green areas are low-rate outlier tracts near high-rate clusters.

High filing rates are clustered almost exclusively on the South and West sides of the city, and they become increasingly concentrated in these areas over time. There are 103 census tracts in the 2010 high-rate cluster, 189 tracts in the 2015 high-rate cluster, and 179 tracts in the 2019 high-rate cluster. In 2010, 83 high-rate tracts were on the South Side, 19 on the West Side, and 1 in the Loop. In 2015, 153 high-rate tracts were on the South Side and 36 on the West Side. In 2019, 138 high-rate tracts were on the South Side, and 41 on the West Side.

The majority of tracts in the low-rate cluster are on the North Side of Chicago, but some are on the West and South Sides. There are 170 tracts in the 2010 low-rate cluster: 142 are in the North, 9 in the South, and 19 in the West. In 2015, there were 207 tracts in the low-rate cluster: 162 in the North Side, 7 in the Central, 9 in the South, and 29 in the West. In 2019, there were 251 tracts in the low-rate cluster: 187 in the North Side, 11 in the Central, 14 in the South, and 39 in the West.

Across all three years, the South-side tracts in the low-rate cluster are located in the Armour Square, Bridgeport, McKinley Park, and Archer Heights community areas. The West-side low-rate tracts are found in the West Town, South Lawndale, Lower West Side, and Near West Side community areas. Low-rate tracts in the Central part of the city are all located in the Near North Side community area. In 2010, there was a small high-rate cluster on the Northwest Side of the city. There are two tracts in this cluster, located in the Hermosa and Belmont-Cragin community areas.

In 2010, there were 12 high-rate outlier tracts: seven on the North Side and five on the South Side. In 2010, there were 23 low-rate outlier tracts: one on the North Side, one in the Central, 18 in the South, and three in the West. In 2015, there were 7 high-rate outliers: three in the North Side, one in the Central, one in the South, and two in the West. There were also 12 low-rate outliers in 2015: eight in the South Side and four in the West. In 2019, there were 9 high-rate outliers: 7 on the North Side, 1 in the South, and 1 in the West. In 2019, there were 10 low-rate outliers: eight in the South Side and two in the West.

	2010		2015		2019	
	High Filing Cluster	***Low Filing Cluster***	***High Filing Cluster***	***Low Filing Cluster***	***High Filing Cluster***	***Low Filing Cluster***
Number of Census Tracts in Sample	103	170	189	207	179	251
Median Value of the Variables						
Eviction Filing Rate	7.01	1.39	7.19	1.15	6.43	0.82
Percent of the Population that is Black	96.10%	2.90%	95.35%	3.24%	94.13%	3.30%
Percentage of the Population that is Latine	1.11%	16.19%	1.81%	14.47%	2.19%	15.24%
Percentage of Households with at Least One Child	37.68%	23.10%	34.74%	21.16%	31.20%	22.85%
Percent of the Population with a Bachelor's Degree or Higher	15.56%	54.57%	12.81%	64.45%	14.86%	62.82%
Percent of the Labor Force that is Unemployed	18.97%	6.43%	25.25%	5.88%	17.79%	3.57%
Percentage of the Housing Stock that is Vacant	19.41%	9.22%	21.66%	8.46%	19.63%	8.19%
Percentage of the Housing Stock that is Owner Occupied	37.09%	43.40%	34.14%	41.22%	32.63%	43.96%
Percentage of the Housing Stock that is Renter Occupied	62.91%	56.60%	65.86%	58.78%	67.37%	56.04%
Assessed Property Value of Census Tract	$ 13,944	$ 30,995	$ 12,334	$ 30,871	$ 12,645	$ 34,933
Household Income	$ 29,539	$ 59,188	$ 26,950	$ 70,701	$ 32,237	$ 80,817
Rent Price	$ 854	$ 970	$ 870	$ 1,150	$ 943	$ 1,313
Rent to Income Ratio	38.8	27.7	40.9	26	39	25.5
2010: n = 797 Census Tracts						
2015: n = 798 Census Tracts						
2019: n = 798 Census Tracts						

Table 2: Differences between Eviction Filing Clusters

	2010		2015		2019	
	High Filing Outlier	***Low Filing Outlier***	***High Filing Outlier***	***Low Filing Outlier***	***High Filing Outlier***	***Low Filing Outlier***
Number of Census Tracts in Sample	12	23	7	12	9	10
Median Value of the Variables						
Eviction Filing Rate	5.915	3.19	4.68	3.445	4.22	2.49
Percent of the Population that is Black	2.00%	73.15%	15.20%	80.39%	8.00%	71.48%
Percentage of the Population that is Latine	7.69%	7.37%	8.46%	3.70%	13.89%	5.93%
Percentage of Households with at Least One Child	27.79%	39.15%	23.39%	27.94%	37.75%	25.92%
Percent of the Population with a Bachelor's Degree or Higher	29.92%	12.91%	58.09%	18.55%	42.11%	15.67%
Percent of the Labor Force that is Unemployed	7.48%	15.73%	8.58%	14.94%	6.27%	14.50%
Percentage of the Housing Stock that is Vacant	8.67%	11.55%	8.75%	11.09%	8.14%	17.33%
Percentage of the Housing Stock that is Owner Occupied	71.33%	42.68%	36.36%	42.86%	48.58%	47.85%
Percentage of the Housing Stock that is Renter Occupied	28.67%	57.32%	63.64%	57.14%	51.42%	52.15%
Assessed Property Value of Census Tract	$ 22,137	$ 13,365	$ 21,028	$ 12,665	$ 32,129	$ 13,645
Household Income	$ 71,479	$ 35,904	$ 59,571	$ 36,692	$ 53,798	$ 40,573
Rent Price	$ 837	$ 818	$ 1,211	$ 903	$ 1,162	$ 964
Rent to Income Ratio	27.9	33.7	29.7	37.75	32.4	32.25
2010: n = 797 Census Tracts						
2015: n = 798 Census Tracts						
2019: n = 798 Census Tracts						

Table 3: Differences Between Eviction Filing Outliers

Demographic, Housing, & Income Differences Between Clusters and Outliers

Table 2 shows the income, housing, and demographic differences between the two cluster types, listing the median value of each sample. The high-rate cluster has a significantly larger Black population than the low-rate ones: in each year, the median percentage of the population that is Black never falls below 94%. In 2010, 75.73% of tracts in the high-rate cluster had a Black population exceeding *90% of the total population*. In 2015, 77.77% of high-rate tracts had a predominantly Black population, and in 2019, 73.18% did. In contrast, the median percentage of the population that is Black in the low-rate clusters is lower than 3.5% across all years. 88.82% of tracts in the 2010 low-rate cluster have a Black population that is *less than 10% of the total population*. In 2015, this was 87.92% of low-rate tracts, and in 2019, 88.84%.

Across all three years, the median percentage of households with children is higher in the high-rate cluster than in the low-rate tracts. This median percentage is 14.58 points higher in 2010, 13.58 points higher in 2015, and 8.35 points higher in 2019. The median assessed property value of census tracts in the high-rate cluster is less than half that of tracts in low-rate clusters. High-rate median assessed values were $17,051 lower in 2010, $18,537 lower in 2015, and $22,288 lower in 2019. These findings indicate that tracts in the high-rate cluster face a greater economic disadvantage than their low-rate counterparts: they have lower median household income, lower median owner-occupancy rate, higher median unemployment rate, and higher median rent-to-income ratio.

Table 3 shows the income, housing, and demographic differences between the two outlier types. These tracts display the opposite phenomenon from the cluster tracts: the low filing rate outliers seem to be at a greater economic disadvantage than the high filing rate outliers. Across all years, the low-rate outliers have a higher rent burden, higher unemployment, a lower owner occupancy rate, lower property values, and a lower education attainment rate than the high-rate outlier tracts.

The high-rate outliers have a much smaller Black population than the low-rate outliers. 58% of the 2010 high-rate outlier tracts had *a Black population that is less than 10% of the total population*. This was 42.58% of the 2015 high-rate outliers, and 66.66% of the 2019 high-rate outliers. In contrast, 43.48% of the low-rate outliers had a Black population that is *greater than 90% of the total population*. This was 41.66% of the 2015 low-rate outliers, and 40% of the 2019 low-rate outliers. The low-rate outliers also had a higher median percentage of households with children: 11.36 percentage points higher in 2010, and 4.55 points higher in 2015. 2019 is the exception: the high-rate outliers had a percentage of households with children that was 11.83 percentage points higher than the low-rate outliers. More research is needed to understand why these tracts have lower eviction rates despite greater economic disadvantage. Investigating the housing options in high-rate outliers may prove interesting: these tracts may have particularly litigious landlords.

2010

*Dependent Variable is eviction filing rate (log **n**)*	*Coefficient*	*Percent of Change*	*Standard Error*	*Significance Level*	*P-value*
Median Assessed Property Value	-0.038	-3.69%	0.003	***	2.25E-28
Percent of Households with Children	0.485	62.45%	0.189	*	0.0101
Household Income	0.003	0.34%	0.002		0.129
Percent of Housing that is Vacant	0.968	163.14%	0.316	**	0.002
Percent of Housing that is Owner Occupied	0.144	15.49%	0.18		0.425
Rent to Income Ratio	0.007	0.66%	0.003		0.056

***: P<.05, **: P<.01, ***: P<.001**

Pseudo R-squ. (CS): 0.3287

Observations = 796 Census Tracts

Table 4: Tweedie Regression Results from 2010

2015

*Dependent Variable is eviction filing rate (log **n**)*	*Coefficient*	*Percent of Change*	*Standard Error*	*Significance Level*	*P-value*
Median Assessed Property Value (by $1,000)	-0.029	-2.82%	0.003	***	3.94E-19
Percent of Households with Children	0.962	161.72%	0.186	***	2.46E-07
Household Income (by $1,000)	-0.005	-0.53%	0.002	**	0.003
Percent of Housing that is Vacant	1.246	247.50%	0.277	***	6.85E-06
Percent of Housing that is Owner Occupied	0.224	25.16%	0.149		0.132
Rent to Income Ratio	0.015	1.52%	0.003	***	9.37E-06

***: P<.05, **: P<.01, ***: P<.001**

Pseudo R-squ. (CS): 0.5526

Observations = 797 Census Tracts

Table 5: Tweedie Regression Results from 2015

2019

*Dependent Variable is eviction filing rate (log **n**)*	*Coefficient*	*Percent of Change*	*Standard Error*	*Significance Level*	*P-value*
Median Assessed Property Value (by $1,000)	-0.031	-3.04%	0.004	***	4.75E-17
Percent of Households with Children	0.651	91.75%	0.26	*	0.012
Household Income (by $1,000)	-0.002	-0.17%	0.002		0.337
Percent of Housing that is Vacant	2.289	886.9%	0.39	***	4.43E-09
Percent of Housing that is Owner Occupied	0.279	32.17%	0.19		0.141
Rent to Income Ratio	0.014	1.43%	0.004	***	8.68E-04

***: P<.05, **: P<.01, ***: P<.001**

Pseudo R-squ. (CS): 0.4305

Observations = 797 Census Tracts

Table 6: Tweedie Regression Results from 2019

Tweedie Regression Analysis

Tables 4, 5, and 6 show the results from the Tweedie Regression analysis. The dependent variable is log-transformed (log n), and the results are reported as percent changes in the dependent variable. The pseudo-R-squared values are: .3287 for the 2010 data; .5526 for the 2015 data; and .4305 for the 2019 data. These values suggest a moderate level of model fit. Both independent variables are statistically significant in each year of data tested. The median assessed property values for a census tract have p-values less than .001 in all three years. The percentage of households with at least one child in a census tract has a p-value less than .05 in 2010 and 2019, and a p-value less than .001 in 2015.

I must reject the null hypothesis that property value and households with children are unrelated to eviction filing rates, while median household income, the percentage of vacant housing, the percentage of owner-occupied housing, and the median rent-to-income ratio are constant. The results show that property values are negatively related to a tract's eviction filing rate. For every $1,000 increase in the median assessed property value, the eviction filing rate drops by 3.7%, 2.8%, and 3%. The percentage of households with children is positively associated with eviction filing rates. For every 1% increase in the number of households with at least one child, eviction filing rates increase by 62%, 162%, and 92%, respectively.

Discussion

Spatial Pattern of Eviction Filings

There is a saying among local urban development researchers: "There is only one map of Chicago". Be it food deserts, violence, or under-resourced schools, cartographic representations of the city's maladies are concentrated in the South and West sides (McClelland, 2023). The threat of eviction must be included in this list. Chicago's dark history of segregation and historic disinvestment are present in these results., and eviction filings look very different depending on where you live.

Looking at the City as a whole, the median eviction filing rate peaks in 2012 and then decreases each year through 2019. The low-rate cluster repeats this pattern. The median filing rate is highest in the 2010 cluster and lowest in the 2019 one. The low-rate cluster even increases in size over time: it has 170 tracts in 2010, 207 in 2019, and 251 in 2019. However, the median filing rate in the high-rate cluster rises by .18 points and grows by 86 tracts between 2010 and 2015. Conditions improved between 2015 and 2019: the median filing rate dropped by 0.76 points, and the number of tracts in the high-rate cluster decreased by 10. One of the biggest limitations of this research is that it only examines three of the ten years available in the eviction data set. A full analysis of the available data is required to better understand how eviction conditions changed over time in areas with a statistically significant high eviction filing rate.

Filing rates are higher in predominantly Black communities that have a lower median household income and a higher proportion of households with children than communities in the low-rate cluster. According to the variables measured, housing conditions are also worse in the high-rate cluster. Rent prices are lower in the high-rate cluster, but not by much. The difference in median rent between high and low-rate clusters is $116 in 2010, $280 in 2015, and $370 in 2019. The high-rate cluster has a higher rent-to-income ratio in each of the years studied. The median rent-to-income ratio is higher by 11.1 points in 2010, 14.9 points in 2015, and 13.5 points in 2019.

The median proportion of owner-occupied housing is lower, as well as the median property value. This indicates not only that there are fewer homeowners in the high-rate cluster, but also that those homes are worth less. However, this study is limited in its measurement of property values. I used the median property value of an entire census tract. Additionally, properties are not sorted by use: the median value includes residential and commercial properties. This study does not capture the variation in property values, and further research is needed to understand how this may affect filing rates.

Relationship Between Filing Rate and Property Values and Percentage of Households With Children

The results of the Tweedie Regression analysis show that as the median assessed property value in a tract increases the filing rate falls. This finding aligns with the literature on the relationship between gentrification and eviction: wealthier areas with higher property values are less likely to experience eviction. Rental properties in neighborhoods with high property values can charge higher rents. Landlords who own buildings in these areas are likely to have measures in place to lease to higher-income tenants who are less likely to miss rent. Tenant displacement may still happen in these areas, but landlords may not have to resort to eviction. There may be enough demand to live in the neighborhood that landlords can raise the rent at the end of the lease. Either the current tenants will pay the higher rent, or they will be replaced with ones that can.

A 1% increase in the number of households with children is associated with a massive 62.45%, 161.72%, and 91.75% increase in the filing rate. This increase may seem unfathomable, but the variable measured is the percent of households with *at least one child*. This model does not measure the relationship between the eviction filing rate and the number of children within a single household; it measures the change from a childless household to one with a child. In a tract with 1000 households, 10 childless homes would have to have a baby to create a 1 percent increase. This is a major economic and demographic change for the census tract, which explains why it's projected to create such a large increase in the filing rate.

As for the control variables, it was surprising that the rent-to-income ratio was associated with such a small increase in the filing rate, and even barely missing the threshold for statistical significance in 2010. Median household income was statistically significant only in 2015 and was associated with a 0.53% decrease in the filing rate. The percentage of owner-occupied housing did not meet the threshold for significance in any of the years tested. The percentage of vacant housing in a census tract is associated with an increase of 163.12%, 247.5%, and 886.9% in the filing rate. However, as with the percentage of households with at least one child, an increase in vacant housing requires an occupied home to lose residents. If 10 of 1,000 housing units in a tract suddenly became vacant, it is reasonable to expect the eviction filing rate to spike.

Conclusion

This research shows that Chicago's most vulnerable communities deal with a high risk of forced displacement. The people living in high-rate areas are predominantly Black, and due to historic disinvestment, these communities have lower incomes, lower property values, and higher rent burdens than areas with low filing rates. Not only do high-rate neighborhoods have more households with children, but the decision to have a child is associated with a higher rate. Housing insecurity increases the financial vulnerability that most working people in the county face.

If eviction filings are tied to missed rent payments, why can't victims of eviction pay rent? The reviewed literature indicates that income and rent price are not significant predictors of eviction, whereas rent burden and job loss are (Desmond & Gershenson, 2017; Immergluck, Ernsthausen, Earl, & Powell, 2020; Robinson & Steil, 2021). The more money a tenant pays toward rent, the less they can contribute to savings or other needs. If they lose their job, they may have no way to pay rent. This financial vulnerability may be especially true for families, who must also incorporate the cost of childcare in their household budget.

Victims of eviction may not be able to pay rent and are being punished for it. This problem is intensified by the housing crisis: there is a nationwide shortage of 7.3 million rental and 3.8 million owner-occupied units (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago, 2026). This lack of housing supply is one of the contributing factors to rising rents. The ability to pay rent depends on two factors: the amount of money you have and the rent price. Victims of eviction in Chicago may be crushed by both.

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